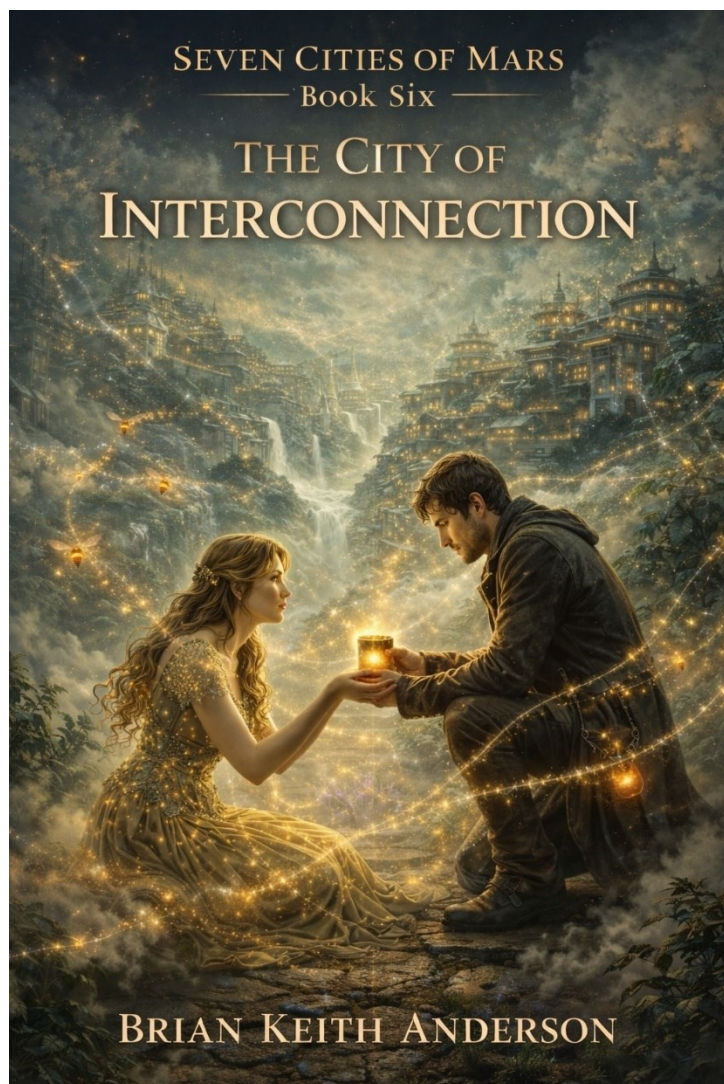




**THE CITY OF
INTERCONNECTION**

Seven Cities of Mars — Book Six

B.K. Anderson

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SERIES PAGE

The Seven Cities of Mars

1. The City of Enduring Light
2. The City of Silence
3. The City of Flowing Currents
4. The City of Restraint
5. The City of Passage
6. The City of Interconnection
7. The City of the Seventh Heart

DEDICATION

For those who discovered
that survival alone was never enough.

And for those who learned
that life continues
only when we belong to one another.

EPIGRAPH

“The hive was never many.

It was always one.”

— The Listener

REFLECTION

There are worlds that survive through strength.

There are worlds that survive through knowledge.

And there are worlds that survive only when every living thing remembers it belongs to every other.

Mars had once forgotten this.

The ancient cities beneath the red sands had been built by races who mastered energy, movement, silence, restraint, and

passage. Yet even the greatest
civilizations had failed when they began
to believe themselves separate.

One by one, the currents between them
weakened.

The woven field unraveled.

The great resonance faded into isolation.

But life does not surrender easily.

Deep beneath the recovering plains of
Mars, hidden systems still listened for
connection. The bees carried it. The bogs
remembered it. And somewhere within

the sleeping foundations of the sixth city,
an ancient network waited for enough
living hearts to choose one another again.

Asa did not yet understand what the bees
had been teaching him all along.

No living thing survives alone.

And some awakenings cannot begin until
many lives learn to move as
one.

Prelude

The first signal was almost too small to notice.

A single bee changed direction in midair.

Not randomly.

Not from wind.

It turned as though it had heard something far below the surface of Mars.

Then another followed.

And another.

Until the entire hive shifted as one living
current beneath the dim amber sky.

Chapter 1 — The Threads Beneath

The first signal was almost too small to notice.

A single bee altered its course beneath the amber haze of the Martian sky, drifting away from the familiar gathering pattern the hive had followed since their arrival near the recovering plains. Asa might have dismissed the movement as random disturbance had the second and third not followed within moments. Soon the entire current of bees shifted together, not

scattering in confusion but flowing with
quiet purpose toward a distant rise of dark
stone partially buried beneath the sands.

Their hum deepened as they moved,
carrying through the thin air with a
resonance he felt more within his chest
than through his ears. Beside him,
Saxifraga stood motionless upon the
ridge, her pale gaze fixed upon the distant
structures emerging through layers of
drifting dust.

The City of Interconnection did not rise
from Mars in the same manner as the

previous cities they had encountered.

Enduring Light had awakened slowly
beneath ancient stillness, while Silence
had hidden itself so completely that even
sound seemed reluctant to cross its
thresholds. Flowing Currents had stirred
through movement, and Passage had
revealed itself through corridors waiting
to be crossed. Yet this city appeared
wounded by division long before their
arrival. Portions of its outer structures
glowed faintly beneath the sand, only to
darken again moments later. Thin lines of
pale illumination traveled through

fractured towers like weakened nerves
struggling to remember forgotten
pathways. Entire sections awakened
briefly, shimmered with life, and then
collapsed once more into shadow.

Asa felt unease settle within him as the
bees continued downward along the
slope. The city did not seem dead. In
many ways, that troubled him more. It
behaved like a living thing trapped
between waking and collapse, aware
enough to struggle yet unable to fully
rise. Far below, enormous bridgeways

stretched between partially exposed towers, many broken in places where centuries of shifting sands had torn them apart. He noticed movement within distant openings, though whether drifting dust or functioning mechanisms he could not tell. The bees showed no hesitation. Their shared hum thickened steadily as they approached the fractured outer boundary, as though something beneath the ancient stone had already recognized them.

“The city listens,” Saxifraga said softly.

Her voice carried no fear, yet Asa heard caution beneath the calmness. He turned toward her, watching the faint silver patterns moving slowly beneath the surface of her skin. He had learned enough through the awakening cities to recognize when she sensed old systems stirring around them. Mars itself seemed quieter here. Even the wind crossing the plains moved in uncertain currents, shifting direction without warning before fading into unnatural stillness. Ahead of them, another pulse of light moved beneath the exposed foundations. This

time the illumination traveled farther
through the buried structures before
abruptly vanishing, as though the city had
attempted to complete a thought and
failed before reaching its end.

Behind them, the hive continued its
descent toward the broken gates of the
sleeping city.

Chapter 2 — Signals Without Meaning

The outer gates of the City of

Interconnection had once been vast

enough to admit entire processional

caravans beneath their arching spans.

Even buried beneath centuries of drifting

dust, the remaining structures dwarfed the

travelers approaching them now. Asa

slowed beside the descending hive as the

bees crossed through shadows cast by

fractured towers leaning at uneasy angles

against one another. Thin currents of pale

light flickered intermittently beneath the

stone beneath his feet, illuminating
ancient pathways before vanishing again
without pattern. Nothing within the city
maintained consistency for long. Every
awakening seemed followed by collapse,
as though countless unseen systems
struggled to remember how they were
meant to function together.

What disturbed Asa most was the
behavior of the bees themselves.

Individual workers moved with
uncertainty unlike anything he had
witnessed before. Small groups separated

from the greater current without warning,
circling exposed walls or drifting into
darkened openings only to emerge
moments later and abruptly change
direction again. Several landed
motionless against ancient surfaces, their
antennae vibrating rapidly as though
attempting to interpret signals too faint or
fragmented to understand. Yet despite the
confusion of the individual movements,
the hive as a whole continued progressing
steadily inward. No collisions occurred.
No panic spread through the swarm. The
greater pattern remained intact even while

countless smaller motions appeared
disordered and uncertain.

Saxifraga knelt beside a partially exposed
section of black stone where narrow veins
of light pulsed beneath translucent layers
embedded within the ancient material.

Her fingertips rested lightly upon the
surface as she closed her eyes. Asa had
seen her commune with the older systems
before, though never with such hesitation.

Usually the cities responded to her
presence with recognizable rhythms, as
though ancient mechanisms still

acknowledged the lineage she carried within her blood. Here the responses came unevenly. The faint glow beneath her hand brightened suddenly, spreading through branching lines extending into the buried structures beyond, only to fracture moments later into scattered pulses traveling in conflicting directions.

“It cannot hold coherence,” she said quietly.

Asa looked upward toward the distant towers where entire sections of the city shimmered briefly into illumination.

Through narrow openings high above, he glimpsed movement within suspended corridors connecting one structure to another. For an instant he believed figures crossed there in silence. Then darkness returned, swallowing the passageways completely. A low vibration moved through the stone beneath them shortly afterward, subtle enough to escape notice had the bees not reacted immediately.

The scattered workers shifted direction all at once, abandoning whatever signals had drawn them moments before as the greater hive altered course toward a

descending avenue partially buried
beneath layers of sand.

The movement unsettled him because no
command appeared to pass between
them.

No single bee guided the others. No
visible pattern explained how the hive
maintained unity while its individual
members behaved as though lost within
conflicting currents. Asa followed slowly
behind, watching one worker spiral
uncertainly near his shoulder before
abruptly accelerating toward the deeper

passages below. It occurred to him then that the confusion belonged not to the bees themselves, but to the signals surrounding them. Something within the City of Interconnection continued transmitting across damaged pathways, sending fractured impulses through systems no longer capable of carrying them cleanly. The hive responded as living water might respond to broken channels—scattering briefly at each fracture before finding the greater flow once more.

Far beneath the dim horizon of Mars,
another pulse traveled through the
wounded city.

This time Asa felt it inside his own chest.